Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Zephaniah

Zephaniah 1:1

- This is the word of the LORD that came: The Lord gave this message to Zephaniah. Zephaniah was a prophet, which means he spoke for God.
- The reference to Hezekiah probably points to King Hezekiah of Judah, who ruled during this time (see 2 Kings 18:1–20:20).

Zephaniah 1:1–2.3

Zephaniah's message from the Lord warns about worldwide judgment (Zephaniah 1:1–6). He urges his readers to repent (Zephaniah 1:7–13) before disaster strikes (1:14–18). He encourages them to seek the Lord and live righteously and humbly, hoping they may avoid his judgment (Zephaniah 2:1–3).

Zephaniah 1:2–3

God's judgment will remove things in the reverse order of their creation (Genesis 1:20–26). People and animals are mentioned first, then birds, and finally fish.

This order shows that judgment is a reversal of creation, moving backward through what God originally made.

Zephaniah 1:4

When Zephaniah made this prophecy, before Josiah's reforms in 622 BC, idolatrous priests actively promoted Baal worship and other forms of paganism (2 Kings 23:5).

Zephaniah 1:4–6

After judging the entire earth (Zephaniah 1:2–3), Zephaniah now focuses on his own people, Judah and Jerusalem.

Zephaniah 1:5

- Scripture condemned the worship of heavenly bodies like the sun, moon, and stars (see Deuteronomy 4:15–19; 2 Kings 21:3; 23:12).
- Milcom was the national god of the Ammonites. In some Old Testament passages, Milcom is closely connected with Molech, a pagan deity linked with child sacrifice. Because of this connection, some texts use these names in overlapping ways.

The law clearly forbade the worship of Molech and related practices (Leviticus 20:1–5). Even so, these forms of worship continued to tempt Israel, especially through contact with neighboring nations (2 Kings 16:3; 21:6).

Zephaniah 1:7

the LORD has prepared a sacrifice; He has consecrated His guests: Foreigners will kill the wicked among the Lord's people.

Zephaniah 1:7–18

We should view the entire passage as one large event. Some parts were fulfilled when Jerusalem fell in 586 BC. Other parts repeated in different historical periods, like the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70. The whole prophecy will be fulfilled at the end of time. Then, God will fully and finally judge the world and renew creation (Revelation 19:11–22:5).

Zephaniah 1:8

The leaders and princes of Judah were:

- the tribal chiefs of Israel (Numbers 1:4),
- court officials (1 Chronicles 22:17),
- district supervisors (1 Kings 20:14–15),
- city officials (Judges 8:6),
- military leaders (1 Kings 2:5; 2 Kings 1:9–14; 25:23, 26), or even
- religious leaders (Ezra 8:24).

Their important roles gave them great responsibility before God (see James 3:1).

Zephaniah 1:9

all who leap over the threshold: The people of Judah continued the pagan custom of jumping over a temple's threshold to avoid touching it, out of respect for that pagan god (see 1 Samuel 5:1–5).

Zephaniah 1:10

The Fish Gate was in the northern part of Jerusalem (Nehemiah 12:39).

Zephaniah 1:13

God would send an invading force to loot Jerusalem. The destruction would happen so fast that those who gained wealth unfairly would not live to enjoy it.

Zephaniah 1:14–18

The meaning of the day of the Lord expands to include God's actions involving the entire earth.

Zephaniah 1:15

darkness and gloom: See also Isaiah 13:9–10; Joel 2:1–2; Amos 5:18–20.

Zephaniah 1:17

walk like the blind: This is an example of God's justice (see also Romans 1:21–32). God's people were blind in their moral choices and in their relationship with him. They could not see what was right or wrong (see Exodus 23:8; Romans 2:19; 1 John 2:11). Because they sinned against the Lord and disobeyed his commands, they received the punishments promised in God's covenant (Deuteronomy 28:28–29).

Zephaniah 2:1–3

After describing the terrifying scene, Zephaniah urges his nation to repent and humble themselves before God.

Zephaniah 2:2

Farmers threshed grain on windy hilltops. They tossed the mixed grain and chaff into the air. The wind blew the chaff away, while the heavier grain fell to the ground. The chance to repent was brief.

Zephaniah 2:3

all you humble: True humility means submitting to and depending on God (Psalms 18:25–27; 119:142–144; Proverbs 15:33; 18:12; 22:4).

Zephaniah 2:4

King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon conquered the Philistine cities of Gaza, Ashkelon, Ashdod, and Ekron. Gaza remained deserted, but the others recovered and continued into later times. Zephaniah does not mention Gath, the fifth major Philistine city (see 1 Samuel 6:17), which had either disappeared or become unimportant by Zephaniah's time.

Zephaniah 2:4–15

Zephaniah started his messages with the Philistines, whose kingdom was west of Judah (Zephaniah 2:4–7). He then addressed Moab and Ammon to the east (Zephaniah 2:8–11), and finally mentioned Cush (Ethiopia) to the south (2:12) and Assyria to the north (2:13–15).

Zephaniah 2:4–3.20

Zephaniah first focuses on judging the foreign nations (Zephaniah 2:4–15). Then, he returns to judging Judah and Jerusalem (Zephaniah 3:1–8). Finally, he describes God's plans for his purified and obedient people (Zephaniah 3:9–20).

Zephaniah 2:5

Old Testament scholars think the Philistines came from the island of Crete (compare Ezekiel 25:16).

Zephaniah 2:6

pastures ... wells for shepherds and folds for sheep: The destruction of cities and their return to nature is a severe punishment from God. See also Isaiah 7:23–25; 13:19–21; 32:9–15; Ezekiel 35:9.

Zephaniah 2:7

The Baal worshipers (Zephaniah 1:4) and the Philistines would never be restored (2:4–6; see also Amos 1:8). In contrast, God promised to bring back the remaining people to their land, care for them, and restore their prosperity (Zephaniah 3:18–20; Isaiah 11:11–16; Jeremiah 23:1–8; Ezekiel 34:11–16, 20–31).

Zephaniah 2:8

- The Moabites and Ammonites were traditional enemies of Israel. The Israelites often fought them (see 2 Kings 3:1–27; 2 Chronicles 20:1–30), and they remained enemies until the end (2 Kings 25:25; Jeremiah 40:11–14).
- taunted ... threatened their borders: The Israelites faced repeated attacks from the Moabites and Ammonites (see Amos 1:13) and also suffered insults about their victories.

Zephaniah 2:9

- The destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah shows God's severe judgment of sin. This is evident in both the Old Testament (Deuteronomy 29:23; Isaiah 1:9; Jeremiah 23:14; Amos 4:11) and the New Testament (Luke 10:12; Romans 9:29; 2 Peter 2:6).
- salt pits: These are areas of ruin (Deuteronomy 29:23; Psalm 107:34; Jeremiah 17:6). Sowing the earth with salt was a sign of permanent judgment (see Judges 9:45) because it made the ground infertile.

Zephaniah 2:11

nations ... will bow in worship to Him: At the end of history, everyone everywhere will worship God alone (Zephaniah 3:9; Psalm 66:4; Micah 4:1–2; Zechariah 14:16).

Zephaniah 2:12

Cushites: While the Hebrew term can refer to any nation or people along the southern edge of the known

world of that time, here it refers specifically to the Ethiopian family of kings that ruled Egypt.

Zephaniah 2:13

Zephaniah shifts focus from the south (Zephaniah 2:12) to the north. Like Nahum before him, he predicts the downfall of Assyria that would happen soon.

Zephaniah 2:14

To emphasize Nineveh's fate, Zephaniah uses strong imagery. Rubble would block the doorways once used by Nineveh's wealthy and powerful. The haunting sounds of owls hooting in empty windows would highlight the city's desolation.

Zephaniah 2:15

- ruin: The destruction was certain and could not be reversed (see Nahum 1:14; 2:13; 3:19). Zephaniah saw no future for Assyria or its capital. Nineveh was so completely destroyed that the Greek historian Xenophon passed by its ruins without knowing it was there.
- hisses and shakes his fist: Those who suffered under Assyria's cruel empire would feel glad seeing it come to an end.

Zephaniah 3:1

Polluted Jerusalem (made unclean by sin and wrongdoing) had turned away from its calling to be a holy city (Isaiah 52:1).

Zephaniah 3:1–8

Zephaniah delivers a message of sorrow for Judah and Jerusalem. He advises them to wait patiently for God's fair judgment.

Zephaniah 3:3–4

See also Ezekiel 22:23–29.

Zephaniah 3:5

He does nothing wrong, unlike those mentioned in Zephaniah 3:3–4.

Zephaniah 3:7

rose early: The people of Jerusalem eagerly got out of bed to commit more evil deeds (compare Proverbs 1:16). They had strayed far from the path of their ancestor Abraham, who rose early to follow God's command (Genesis 22:3).

Zephaniah 3:8

- wait for Me: See Habakkuk 2:3.
- rise to testify: The prophet describes a courtroom scene. God first acts as a witness (see also Jeremiah 29:23; Malachi 3:5) on his own behalf, then serves as judge (see also Job 9:15; Psalm 50:6) to give his fair sentence.
- The fire of my jealousy refers to the Lord's rightful anger against sin. It also shows his care for his holy name and his people's well-being (see Isaiah 66:13–16).

Zephaniah 3:9

God plans for the blessings promised to the faithful remnant in Zephaniah 3:9–13 to reach people from every nation. Not just Israel, but all people will transform, call on the Lord (see Isaiah 55:5), and serve him (see Isaiah 59:19–21; Zechariah 14:16). Spreading the good news to all nations helped fulfill this vision (Matthew 28:19–20; Romans 10:9–13).

Zephaniah 3:9–13

The bright future described in these verses gives more reason to wait patiently for the Lord (Zephaniah 3:8). Like the prophets Isaiah, Nahum, and Habakkuk, Zephaniah uses judgment and hope as main themes.

Zephaniah 3:9–20

God shows his plans for a humble and pure group of his people (Zephaniah 3:9–13). He encourages them to rejoice in the coming abundant blessings from their saving Lord (Zephaniah 3:14–20).

Zephaniah 3:10

The rivers of Ethiopia are the distant sources of the Nile River. In ancient times, people saw the Nile's origin as a great mystery. This expression refers to the farthest parts of the earth.

Zephaniah 3:12

Jesus the Messiah, God's chosen one, perfectly shows the moral qualities expected of the faithful people of Israel (Isaiah 42:1–4; 53:3, 7–9; Zechariah 9:9; see Matthew 11:28–30; 12:15–21; Philippians 2:1–8; 1 Peter 2:23).

Zephaniah 3:14

Sing ... shout aloud ... Be glad and rejoice!: These commands together show that God's people will one day experience very great joy.

Zephaniah 3:15

- The true king of Israel was always meant to be the Lord (Numbers 23:21; 1 Samuel 8:7; Isaiah 44:6).
- is among you: See also Isaiah 54:4–8; 57:14–19; 62:10–12; Ezekiel 48:35; Joel 3:17, 21.

Zephaniah 3:17

- mighty to save: God served as Israel's divine warrior and redeemer (see Psalm 24:8–10; Isaiah 42:13; Habakkuk 3:8–15). One of God's titles is "the Mighty God" (Isaiah 10:21). This title also refers to the Messiah (Isaiah 9:6).
- He will rejoice over you: Jerusalem and all Israel will rejoice in God (Zephaniah 3:14), and God will rejoice over them as a purified and faithful people (see 3:12–13).

Zephaniah 3:18

I will gather ... no longer suffer reproach: The Lord's promise is very different from the warnings at the start of the book. First, God threatened to gather the nations to remove the people of Judah from the earth (Zephaniah 1:2–4). Now, he promises to gather those exiled from Jerusalem and lead them safely home.

Zephaniah 3:18–20

The repeated use of I will in these verses emphasises God's promises to his people.

Zephaniah 3:19

God will change his people's past shame into glory and fame (see Deuteronomy 26:19; Isaiah 62:7; Micah 4:6–8; compare 1 Peter 5:4).

Zephaniah 3:20

- At that time: After a period of severe anger and judgment, the day of the Lord ends with eternal blessings for everyone who trusts in him (Zephaniah 3:9, 12; see Psalm 2:12; Isaiah 45:22; see also Revelation 19:11–22:5).
- says the LORD: Zephaniah's prophecy, entirely from God (see also Zephaniah 1:1–3, 10; 2:9; 3:8), is completely trustworthy.